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Head Level Game System of Play Over a Raised Game Field

Abstract

A game system according to at least one embodiment includes: a flexible field sheet having multiple head openings; multiple tensile lines for suspending the field sheet; at least one target for placement on the field sheet; and a game piece for use in conjunction with the target for game play. The target and game piece are soccer themed. A method of playing a game according to at least one embodiment includes: suspending a flexible field sheet having multiple head opening; passing player heads through the head openings from below the field sheet; placing a mobile game piece onto the field sheet; and moving the game piece by deformation of the field sheet from below the field sheet by player hands. A kit may include a container in which the game system can be shipped and stored.

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Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATION [0001] This application claims the benefit of priority of U.S. provisional patent application No. 63/563,457, titled “Head Level Game System of Play Over a Raised Game Field,” filed on Mar. 10, 2024, which is incorporated herein in its entirety by this reference.

TECHNICAL FIELD

[0002] The present disclosure relates generally to games and sporting activities, and more particularly to a field sport simulated by a suspended field sheet and player manipulation of a mobile game piece.

BACKGROUND

[0003] Activity gaming can be used for exercise and maintenance or mobility. Typical games available in homes and facilities such as retirement homes, hospitals, care centers, and training centers are board games and card games for seated play without encouragement of player movement beyond moving playing pieces on a game board or the holding and manipulation of cards.

[0004] Games, especially those encouraging movements, are needed for fun, competition, education, and social development. Improvements in game systems are needed to encourage player movement.

SUMMARY

[0005] This summary is provided to briefly introduce concepts that are further described in the following detailed descriptions. This summary is not intended to identify key features or essential features of the claimed subject matter, nor is it to be construed as limiting the scope of the claimed subject matter.

[0006] A game system according to at least one embodiment includes: a flexible field sheet having multiple head openings; multiple tensile lines for suspending the field sheet; at least one target for placement on the field sheet; and a game piece for use in conjunction with the target for game play.

[0007] The target and game piece are soccer themed.

[0008] A method of playing a game according to at least one embodiment includes: suspending a flexible field sheet having multiple head opening; passing player heads through the head openings from below the field sheet; placing a mobile game piece onto the field sheet; and moving the game piece by deformation of the field sheet from below the field sheet by player hands and by players heads above the field sheet.

[0009] A kit according to at least one embodiment includes: a container; a flexible field sheet in the container, the field sheet having multiple head openings; multiple tensile lines in the container; the tensile lines for suspending the field sheet; at least one target in the container, the target for placement on the field sheet; a game piece for use in conjunction with the target for game play; and an article of game play rules in the container. The field sheet may have pre-placed grommets to anchor the tensile lines.

[0010] The above summary is to be understood as cumulative and inclusive. The above and below described features are to be understood as combined in whole or in part in various embodiments whether expressly described herein or implied by at least this reference. For brevity, not all features are expressly described and illustrated as combined with all other features. No combination of features shall be deemed unsupported for merely not appearing expressly in the drawings and descriptions.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0011] The previous summary and the following detailed descriptions are to be read in view of the drawings, which illustrate some, but not all, embodiments and features as briefly described below. The summary and detailed descriptions, however, are not limited to only those embodiments and features explicitly illustrated.

[0012] FIG. 1 is a perspective view of a head level game system according to at least one embodiment.

[0013] FIG. 2 is an elevation view of the head level game system of FIG. 1 in play according to at least one use.

[0014] FIG. 3 is a perspective view of the field sheet and supporting tensile lines of the head level game system of FIG. 1.

[0015] FIG. 4 is a perspective view of an upright target, according to at least one embodiment, for optional use with the head level game system of FIG. 1.

[0016] FIG. 5 is a perspective view of a two-piece upright target, according to at least one embodiment, for optional use with the head level game system of FIG. 1.

[0017] FIG. 6 is an elevation view of a portion of the field sheet of FIG. 3, with an exemplary head opening according to at least one embodiment.

[0018] FIG. 7 is a perspective view of a portion of the field sheet of FIG. 3, with an exemplary head opening according to at least another embodiment.

[0019] FIG. 8 is a perspective view of a portion of the field sheet of FIG. 3, with an exemplary head opening according to at least yet another embodiment.

[0020] FIG. 9 is a perspective view of a game kit, according to at least one embodiment, including the game system of FIG. 1 and illustrated optional elements.

[0021] FIG. 10 is a perspective view of a head level game system, according to at least one embodiment, having a raised field sheet as in FIG. 3, and a top-side enclosure for capture of a game piece.

[0022] FIG. 11 is a perspective view of a head level game system, according to at least one embodiment, having a raised circular field sheet as in FIG. 3, and a corresponding top side enclosure for capture of a game piece.

[0023] FIG. 12 is a cross-sectional view of a junction of respective ends of tubular poles maintained as joined at a sleeve by a tensioned internal shock cord.

DETAILED DESCRIPTIONS

[0024] These descriptions are presented with sufficient details to provide an understanding of one or more particular embodiments of broader inventive subject matters. These descriptions expound upon and exemplify particular features of those particular embodiments without limiting the inventive subject matters to the explicitly described embodiments and features. Considerations in view of these descriptions will likely give rise to additional and similar embodiments and features without departing from the scope of the inventive subject matters. Although steps may be expressly described or implied relating to features of processes or methods, no implication is made of any particular order or sequence among such expressed or implied steps unless an order or sequence is explicitly stated.

[0025] Any dimensions expressed or implied in the drawings and these descriptions are provided for exemplary purposes. Thus, not all embodiments within the scope of the drawings and these descriptions are made according to such exemplary dimensions. The drawings are not necessarily made to scale. Thus, not all embodiments within the scope of the drawings and these descriptions are made according to the apparent scale of the drawings with regard to relative dimensions in the drawings. However, for each drawing, at least one embodiment is made according to the apparent relative scale of the drawing.

[0026] Any materials described are provided as non-limiting examples except where their inclusion

is positively and unambiguously asserted. Once materials and arrangements are described herein with reference to any structures and elements thereof, for example in the drawings, such descriptions apply as well to any further same or similar structures and elements that may appear in other drawings.

[0027] Like reference numbers used throughout the drawings depict like or similar elements. Unless described or implied as exclusive alternatives, features throughout the drawings and descriptions should be taken as cumulative, such that features expressly associated with some particular embodiments can be combined with other embodiments.

[0028] Unless defined otherwise, technical and scientific terms used herein have the same meaning as commonly understood to one of ordinary skill in the art to which the presently disclosed subject matter pertains.

[0029] A game system **10** includes a raised flexible field sheet **20** suspended at a height of approximately player neck level for head level game play by passage of player heads through head openings **22** in the field sheet and player manipulation of a mobile game piece **40** to move the game piece, such as a ball, which moves on and above the field sheet. Players **5** (FIG. **2**) may manipulate the game piece **40** by deformation of the field sheet **20** from below the field sheet by hand as shown in FIG. **2**, indirectly contacting the game piece through the field sheet. Players may also manipulate the game piece **40** by direct head contact above the field sheet. Players enjoy a field level perspective or view above the field sheet **20**, with the game piece **40** and other player's heads in view upon the field. The players may be seated, standing, or otherwise situated below the field sheet.

[0030] In the embodiment of FIG. **1**, the raised field sheet is suspended essentially horizontally, supported at its corners by multiple respective tensile lines **50**, each attached to a respective support element **52**, illustrated in FIG. **1** as a post. The game system can be used outdoors and indoors, and can accordingly be supported by various and varied available and/or arranged support elements, and by game assistants **7** (FIG. **2**) and players **5**. Other examples of support elements include, but are not limited to: architectural elements such as doors (FIG. **2**), stair rails; furniture items such as dressers, tables, and chairs; outdoors elements such as trees, rocks, and fence posts.

[0031] Game play may include scoring by players by directing the game piece through, into, in contact with, or in proximity with a target **60**. In the example illustrated in FIG. **1**, the gaming system **10** is themed as a small scale simulated soccer game. Accordingly, in FIG. **1**, the game piece **40** is spherically shaped and colorized or otherwise patterned as a soccer ball in appearance, having alternating black and white polygonal portions. Similarly, two targets are opposed across the field sheet, each formed to appear as a soccer goal. In the illustrated embodiment, each target has a rectangular frame with spaces spanned or closed out by nets along its sides and back end to capture a game piece entering the target, and an opening for receiving the game piece along the front end for scoring. The field sheet is also themed alike or similar to the game piece and targets, appearing at least in part as a soccer field with soccer goals and lined field markings **30**, for example in white, upon a green background color.

[0032] In other embodiments, a target **62** illustrated in FIG. **4** has an arch with an opening optionally closed out by a net. A target **64** illustrated in FIG. **5** includes two posts (**64A**, **64B**), for example for spaced positioning on a field sheet as in FIG. **3** or another field sheet embodiment. Other target examples are within the scope of these descriptions. Many game and activity themes having corresponding target types are within the scope of these descriptions and thus are not all expressly illustrated. Game play associated with the embodiment of FIG. **1** may include scoring when the game piece enters either target **60**. Game play associated with the target **62** of FIG. **4** may include scoring when the game piece passes through or under the arch, for example contacting the net where the net is included. Game play associated with the target **64** of FIG. **5** may include scoring when the game piece passes between the posts **64A** and **64B** spaced on a field sheet. Many variations may occur and many playing examples, having established or player concocted rules

may be followed according to human preferences.

[0033] The positions of targets on field sheets, in some embodiments, are represented by target position field markings **18** (FIG. **3**) on the field sheet **20**, and may be implemented as corresponding fixing elements at and/or defining the field markings. Hook and loop fabric portions may be used as fixing elements for attaching targets to field sheets, the targets having hook or loop patches **66** (FIGS. **1**, **4-5**) at the bases for example, and the field having opposite loop or hook patches. Other examples of fixing elements for conveniently and removably attaching targets to field sheets for game play, and removing same for storage and shipping, are within the scope of these descriptions.

[0034] Targets described and illustrated herein may have upright, expanded, unfolded, and inflated configurations, for game play use. For convenient storage, handling, and shipping, the targets may have conversely corresponding lowered, reduced, folded, and deflated configurations. Targets may, for example, be assembled and disassembled by players or assistants. In some examples, the targets may have multiple rigid elements temporarily attached together by fixing elements such as hook and loop fabric patches. Some of the illustrated target embodiments are shown with inflation valves for inflation and deflation. The illustrated valves **70** are shown as the type by which the inflatable subject can be inflated by breath and/or with tools or pumps, and include attached sealing caps for convenient use. Other valves within the scope of these descriptions, including needle inflation valves as used for inflatable sports balls.

[0035] The game piece **40** illustrated can be a filled ball having an outer skin or cover such as fabric and internal soft fill material such as foam, fibrous batting, and/or other particulate matter so as to be non-injurious to players. The game piece **40** may otherwise be inflatable and deflatable by way of a valve **70** (FIG. **9**). A game piece within the scope of these descriptions may have upright, expanded, unfolded, and inflated configuration, for game play use and may have conversely corresponding lowered, reduced, folded, and deflated configurations.

[0036] The tensile lines **50** can be of various types in various embodiments. Examples include but are not limited to cords, ties, stretchy material, resilient material, shock cords, ropes, twines, ribbons, tethers, and hide. The tensile lines can be made from natural materials such as cotton and hemp. The tensile lines can be made of synthetic materials, for example polymers such as nylon, polyethylene or polyvinylidene fluoride (“fluorocarbon”) and may come as monofilament or braided (multifilament) forms. The tensile lines can include natural and synthetic materials. In the embodiment of FIG. **3**, each tensile line **50** is attached to a respective corner of a rectangular field sheet **20**, for example by way grommets at the corners, and at edge mid field points (FIG. **3**) to better support the field sheet. Embodiments can include other and/or additional arrangements, for example, six or eight grommets fixed to the field sheet: 4 corners, 2 to 4 edge points central along edges. In other embodiments the tensile lines may be attached by stitching, tying, and/or other fixing elements.

[0037] The field sheet **20** is flexible and supple, permitting sliding of player hands in deforming the field sheet to direct movement of the ball for scoring attempts, blocking attempts, and passing among players. The field sheet can be constructed, in non-limiting examples, as a woven sheet of natural or synthetic materials, a combination of natural and synthetic materials. The stock material from which a field sheet according to these descriptions is constructed can include, but is not limited to, bedding sheet material, drop cloth material, and parachute material such as ripstop nylon, terylene, and Kevlar, having advantageous properties of strength, tear resistance, elasticity, and permeability. The stock material from which a field sheet according to these descriptions is constructed can include plastic film and/or woven nylon.

[0038] For passage of player heads through the field sheet, the head openings **22** are spaced and arranged along the field sheet to separate player heads. In the illustrated embodiment of FIG. **1**, and as referenced in FIG. **3**, three central head openings **22A** arranged on the first half field **20A** define three first team player positions for players defending a first end target **60** proximal the outer edge

of the first half field **20A** and scoring by attacking a second end target **60** proximal the outer edge of the second half field **20B**. Two peripheral head openings **22B** define two second team player positions for players attacking first end target **60** proximal the outer edge of the first half field **20A**. Similar head openings are arranged on the second end half field **20B** symmetrically across a marked field center line with similar definition as those described with team distinction reversed. [0039] FIG. 2 illustrates game play in an exemplary scenario of use. In the illustrated game play, one first team player **5** in the first half field **20A** and one opposing second team player **5** in the second half field **20B** are shown. Other game play examples include other player numbers and arrangements. Game play can be flexible as to the number and positions of players for light-hearted play, or more regimented with adherence to rules and referee attendants and/or game assistants (FIG. 2). Fixed position and/or wheeled chairs may be used, for example wheel chairs **3** and/or pivoting and rolling office chairs **7**, may be used as illustrated in FIG. 2. Stools, chairs, stands, benches, couches, and other types of chairs and human supports are within the scope of these descriptions for use with the game systems.

[0040] Examples of head openings are shown in FIGS. 6-8. A head opening (**22**, **22A**, **22B**) may be defined and supported by a sewn and/or layered perimeter **24** (FIG. 6). A head opening (**22**, **22A**, **22B**) may be defined as a slit with rip stop material **26**, for example of glue or epoxy or other binder to form saturated composite areas at ends of the slit (FIG. 7), or attached fabric patches. A head opening (**22**, **22A**, **22B**) can have hook and loop closure strips **28** (FIG. 8) to close out the head opening when no player is present at the corresponding game field position. Zippered and tied closures may be used in other examples. The openings may be formed by blade, scissor, or other edged tool, and may be formed by a heated element or heat application so as to form the opening while fusing sheet fibers along the opening to prevent fraying.

[0041] A game kit (FIG. 9) can include the various elements of the game system (FIG. 1) in a container **80** for storage and shipping. The container **80** can be or include a box as illustrated and/or further packaging items such as a shipping bag and padding. The container may have themed graphical and text indicia matching the theme of the game system **10**. The targets **60** and game piece **40** can be in reduced form, such as deflated, in the package. The field sheet **20** is folded in the illustrated example of FIG. 9, and placed in the container. The tensile lines can be in a tied configuration, and may come as a spool **54** of tensile line for dispensation by users to suitable lengths depending on the environment of use.

[0042] At least one embodiment of a game kit and a game system, otherwise according to above descriptions, can be provided and used without targets, for game play as passing among players and other game play options according to player imagination and preference.

[0043] An article of game play rules **82** may be included with the game system and/or kit. Any particular embodiment of an article of rules can have text and/or graphical indicia particularly associated with the particular associated embodiment of the game system, describing suggested game play principles and specifications for scoring and counting. The article of rules can, for example, be paper or card stock, optionally folded, with text and/or graphical indicia expressing suggested game play. In the soccer themed example, the article of rules for example can describe game piece manipulation from below the field sheet by hand, indirectly contacting the game piece through the field sheet, and by direct head contact above the field sheet.

[0044] The uncovered game system of FIG. 3 is convenient for storage size and economy. Other embodiments of game systems according to these descriptions have top-side enclosures for capture of a game piece. FIG. 10 is a perspective view of a head level game system **100**, according to at least one embodiment, having a raised field sheet **20** as in FIG. 3, and a top-side enclosure **110** for capture of a game piece. The field sheet is previously described in the preceding with reference to FIGS. 1-3. The foot print of the top-side enclosure **110** matches the perimeter shape of the raised field sheet **20** (FIG. 3), such that a captured game piece is always in play and no out of bounds areas are defined. Optionally, the field sheet has one or more escape hole, for example as described

with reference to FIG. 11.

[0045] In the embodiment of FIG. 10, the field sheet is raised upon and supported by perimeter legs 102. The game system may have a horizontal and field level perimeter frame 106 to which the legs 102 are attached, optionally removably attached. The legs 102 are illustrated as having feet 104 for stabilization. The enclosure 110 is illustrated as held raised by flexed support poles 112 connected at their lower ends to the perimeter frame and are interconnected or joined at the upper ends, for example via a dome piece 114. The frame 106, the legs 102, and the support poles 112, may each be sectioned and/or otherwise disjoinable for disassembly and storage of the game system 100. For example, sections of each may be constructed as hollow flexible tubes of flexible material such as fiberglass and/or other composite. Joinable ends of the sections may be removably joined together by ferrules and/or sleeves, and may be held as joined by tensioned shock cord passed through the hollow interiors as illustrated in FIG. 12.

[0046] FIG. 11 is a perspective view of a head level game system 200, according to at least one embodiment, having a raised elliptical and/or circular field sheet, which is otherwise described with reference to the field sheet 20 in the preceding, and a corresponding top side enclosure for capture of a game piece. The foot print of the top-side enclosure 210 matches the perimeter shape of the raised field sheet 20 (FIG. 3), such that a captured game piece is always in play and no out of bounds areas are defined.

[0047] The enclosures 110 and 210 may each be defined as raised walls, for example constructed of mesh as represented by the section 211 in FIG. 11, with other portions shown transparent for view of the field sheet in FIG. 11. The enclosure walls are at least partially see-through for observation of the playing area by fans, attendants, and/or people awaiting their turn at play. The enclosure 210 and sections 211 may be seamed and/or attached to the outer perimeter of the field sheet as illustrated.

[0048] In the illustrated elliptical and/or circular field sheet with the corresponding top side enclosure, and similarly for other elliptical, oval, and some non-rectangular many-sided polygonal field sheets, there are no deep corners where a game piece may come to rest and be trapped out of reach of players.

[0049] Optionally, the field sheet has one or more escape hole 208, for example arranged below or proximal a target (60 FIG. 1, 62 FIG. 4, 64 FIG. 5) and defined through the field sheet as represented by placement of each escape hole 208 in FIG. 11 as between a respective pair of field markings 18 described with reference to FIG. 3. Scoring during gaming in use of the game system 200 and other embodiments having escape holes can be defined by escape of a game piece from the enclosure through an escape hole. An escape hole can also be defined through the raised wall of the enclosure.

[0050] In the embodiment of FIG. 11, the field sheet is raised upon and supported by perimeter legs 202. The game system 200 has a horizontal and a field level perimeter frame 206 to which the legs 102 are attached, optionally removably attached. The legs 202 may have feet 104 (FIG. 10) for stabilization. The enclosure 210 is illustrated as held raised by flexed support poles 212, which are connected at their lower ends to the perimeter frame and are interconnected or joined at the upper ends, for example via a dome piece 214. The frame 206, the legs 202, and the support poles 212, may each be sectioned and/or otherwise disjoinable for disassembly and storage of the game system 200. For example as shown in enlarged view in FIG. 12 for a representative portion 216 (FIG. 11) of a support pole 212, sections of each may be constructed as hollow flexible tubes 220 of flexible material such as fiberglass and/or other composite. Joinable ends of the sections may be removably joined together by ferrules and/or sleeves 222, and may be held as joined by tensioned shock cord 224 passed through the hollow interiors as illustrated in FIG. 12. Each section of the frame 206 and support poles 212 may be effectively coupled to the enclosure and field sheet by fabric sleeves attached to the field sheet and enclosure.

[0051] A game system according to embodiments within the scope of these descriptions can be

used in homes for recreation, in offices for work breaks and team building, in recreation rooms of facilities, retirement homes, hospitals, care centers, training centers, and can be used indoors and outdoors. Players can include children and adults of all ages and energy levels. Benefits can include improvements in morale, fitness, coordination, flexibility, mental acuity, therapy, general life skills such as communication skills, and humor and bonding among participants.

[0052] Particular embodiments and features have been described with reference to the drawings. It is to be understood that these descriptions are not limited to any single embodiment or any particular set of features, and that similar embodiments and features may arise or modifications and additions may be made without departing from the scope of these descriptions and the spirit of the appended claims.

Claims

1. A game system comprising: a flexible field sheet having multiple head openings; multiple tensile lines for suspending the field sheet; at least one target for placement on the field sheet; and a game piece for use in conjunction with the target for game play.
 2. A game system according to claim 1, wherein the target and game piece are soccer themed.
 3. A method of playing a game comprising: suspending a flexible field sheet having multiple head openings; passing player heads through the head openings from below the field sheet; placing a mobile game piece onto the field sheet; and moving the game piece by deformation of the field sheet from below the field sheet by player hands.
 4. A kit comprising: a container; a flexible field sheet in the container, the field sheet having multiple head openings; multiple tensile lines in the container; the tensile lines for suspending the field sheet; at least one target in the container, the target for placement on the field sheet; a game piece for use in conjunction with the target for game play; and an article of game play rules in the container.
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